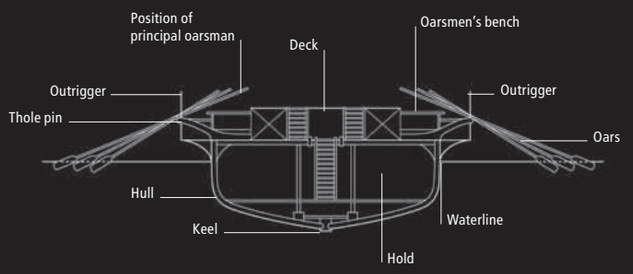
ABOVE DECK

THE GALERA REAL mounted five cannon on the raised fighting platform or forecastle at the prow and four lighter artillery pieces. Going into battle, soldiers were stationed around the galley from the bow to the stern, many of them armed with arquebuses. The galley was rowed *a scaloccio*, with four men to a single oar. Although elaborately decorated, the poop functioned as the center of armed resistance if the galley was boarded in battle, fighting men clustering there to defend their flag and their commmander. At Lepanto the galley was rammed by the Turkish flagship, the enemy prow penetrating as far inboard as the fourth oarsman.



Cross-section of galley
The galley has 30 oars on the starboard (right) side and 29 on the port (left) side, with four oarsmen to each oar. As the men rowed the inside oarsman had to move further than the others, rising to his feet as he pressed on the foot brace in front of him to pull the oar through the water.

» Interior of the poop
The poop deck, where Don John and his officers spent most of their time, was richly decorated with marquetry. The scenes on the backrest of the bench are episodes from Greek mythology, most having a nautical angle as well as a moral point to make.





» Canopy and awning
The admiral's quarters on the poop deck did not have a permanent roof. When necessary the canopy would be covered with a large cloth to keep out the sun or the wind and rain. This covering was also used in battle.